

Project 3
Group 6
IT372 - DL1: Applied Generative AI
02/01/2026
Professor Azamy
Lily DeBell and Flo Lawendy

Step 1

- a. **Research question (RQ):** How can college students and young adults improve their chances of getting internships or entry-level jobs without professional experience or paid career services?
- SubQ1:** What resume and cover letter strategies help entry-level candidates get interviews when they lack formal experience?
 - SubQ2:** How does optimizing LinkedIn profiles and personal branding affect recruiter visibility for students and new grads?
 - SubQ3:** Which interview preparation methods best predict early job success and retention for entry-level employees?

Step 2

Claim	Source	Link	Source type	Is Authoritative Source?	What it supports	Notes
It is possible for university students to find internships and entry-level jobs and build a strong resume without formal work experience.	Perplexity deep research: University of Florida "Five Tips to Building a Resume without Work Experience"	https://career.ufl.edu/five-tips-to-building-a-resume-without-work-experience/	University (edu)	Yes	RQ/SubQ1	Supports Main RQ/SubQ1 by stating ways entry-level candidates and students can pad their resume when they lack formal job experience.
Traits that employers most often look for are the ability to solve problems, teamwork,	Perplexity deep research: NACE "The Key Attributes	https://acc reditation.ncsu.edu/ wp-content/u ploads/site	University (edu)	Yes	SubQ1	Shows what employers are actually looking for beyond formal job experience and lays out specific

Claim	Source	Link	Source type	Is Authoritative Source?	What it supports	Notes
written communication, initiative, strong work ethic, technical skills, analytical skills, and internship experience within the organization or industry.	Employers are Looking for on Graduates' Resumes"	s/221/drive/1TPu5pjAm02cab616yNMq81WTm114pTcQ/QEP-As-Their-Focus-on-GPA-Fades.pdf				resume characteristics to answers SubQ1
For students and new grads, social media and personal branding is crucial to employer visibility and perceived employability	Perplexity deep research: National Library of Medicine "Get Noticed to Get Ahead: The Impact of Personal Branding on Career Success"	https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6913621/	Government (.gov)	Yes	SubQ2	Optimizing LinkedIn profile & Personal Branding
For students and recent grads, academic qualifications, work experience, and extracurricular activities, strong academics or extracurriculars can partly	Elicit: Semantic Scholar "Recruiters' Perceptions and Use of Applicant Résumé Information: Screening the Recent	https://www.semanticscholar.org/paper/Recruiters%E2%80%9999-Perceptions-and-Use-of-Applicant-	Peer reviewed journal article	Yes	SubQ1	

Claim	Source	Link	Source type	Is Authoritative Source?	What it supports	Notes
compensate for limited work experience on a resume.	Graduate"	R%C3%A9sum%C3%A9-Cole-Rubin/6834fa2dafabafb0f0123c6a818083a6455bcd1a				
Practicing structural methods, such as STAR(Situation, Task, Action, Result) is a good predictor of hireability and early job success for employees.	Perplexity deep research: OPM "Structured Interviews"	https://www.opm.gov/policy-data-oversight/assessment-and-selection/other-assessment-methods/structured-interviews/	Government (.gov)	Yes	SubQ3	Interview preparation
Internships and experiential learning significantly improve early career success, salary, and job satisfaction for graduates.	NACE "Internships, Experiential Learning Impact Early Career Success"	https://www.naceweb.org/about-us/press/internships-experiential-learning-impact-early-	Recognized Organization (Professional Association Research Report)	Yes	SubQ1	Shows real career outcome benefits of internships and hands-on learning for college students.

Claim	Source	Link	Source type	Is Authoritative Source?	What it supports	Notes
		career-success				
University internships can increase graduate wages and improve long-term employment outcomes through skill development and real-world experience.	Springer / Research in Higher Education “Valuable Experience: How University Internships Affect Graduates’ Income”	https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s11162-021-09637-9	Peer-Reviewed Journal Article	Yes	SubQ1	Peer-reviewed research showing measurable income increases from internships.
Many graduates feel unprepared for entry-level jobs because of skill gaps, and employers increasingly value real-world skills, connections, and experience.	Cengage Group “2025 Graduate Employability Report”	https://www.cengagegroup.com/news/press-releases/2025/cengage-group-2025-employability-report/	Industry Research Report (EdTech / Workforce Research Organization)	Yes	SubQ3	Shows real hiring trends and the importance of practical skills, networking, and experience.

Step 3

Claim	Source	Link	Source type	Is Authoritative Source?	What it supports	Notes	Verified? (Y/N)	Evidence Snipped (1 Line)	Tradeoffs/Conflicts
It is possible for university students to find internships and entry-level jobs and build a strong resume without formal work experience.	Perplexity deep research: University of Florida "Five Tips to Building a Resume without Work Experience"	https://career.ufl.edu/five-tips-to-building-a-resume-without-work-experience/	University (edu)	Yes	RQ/SubQ1	Supports Main RQ/SubQ1 by stating ways entry-level candidates and students can pad their resume when they lack formal job experience .	Y	University students can gain experience through volunteering, unpaid internships, campus involvement, and class projects.	Gaining experience through volunteering, unpaid internships, or campus involvement builds resume strength but may require significant unpaid time, which can be difficult for students who need paid work to support themselves financially.
For students and new grads, social media and personal branding is crucial to employer visibility and	Perplexity deep research: National Library of Medicine "Get Noticed to	https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6913621/	Government (.gov)	Yes	SubQ2	Optimizing LinkedIn profile & Personal Branding	Y	The research paper was a product of two studies, where the finding of both showed that people who marketed	Building a strong personal brand can increase employer visibility and career

Claim	Source	Link	Source type	Is Authoritative Source?	What it supports	Notes	Verified? (Y/N)	Evidence Snipped (1 Line)	Tradeoffs/Conflicts
perceived employability	Get Ahead: The Impact of Personal Branding on Career Success”							themselves to potential employers demonstrated better chances of being perceived as employable and a better career satisfaction later on.	opportunities, but it requires time, consistency, and public online presence, which may raise privacy concerns or disadvantage students unfamiliar with professional networking platforms.
For students and recent grads, academic qualifications, work experience, and extracurricular activities, strong academics or extracurriculars can partly compensate for limited work	Elicit: Semantic Scholar “Recruiters’ Perceptions and Use of Applicant Résumé Information: Screening	https://www.semanticscholar.org/paper/Recruiters%E2%80%99-Perceptions-and-Use-of-Applicant-R%C3%A9sum%C3%A9-Information: Screening/Cole-Rubin/6834fa2dafabafb0f0	Peer reviewed journal article	Yes	SubQ 1	Accessed full article by searching the title in the GMU library database	Y	This article reviews the three major categories of resumes and the evidence demonstrates that regarding students and recent graduates, recruiters view resumes	Strong academics and extracurriculars can help offset lack of work experience, but some industries and employers still

Claim	Source	Link	Source type	Is Authoritative Source?	What it supports	Notes	Verified? (Y/N)	Evidence Snipped (1 Line)	Tradeoffs/Conflicts
experience on a resume.	the Recent Graduate”	123c6a818083a6455bcd1a						holistically, and a lack of formal work experience can be compensated for by high grades or being involved in extracurriculars .	prioritize direct job experience, meaning students may face limited opportunities in experience-heavy fields.
Internships increase job offers, starting salary, and early career success for college graduates.	NACE “Internships, Experiential Learning Impact Early Career Success”	https://naceweb.org/about-us/press/internships-experiential-learning-impact-early-career-success	Recognized Organization (Career / Workforce Research Organization)	Yes	SubQ 1		Y	Graduates who complete internships receive more job offers and higher starting salaries than peers without internship experience.	Internships improve job outcomes, but access can be unequal, and some internships are unpaid, creating financial barriers for some students.
Structured or behavioral interviews are better predictors of job	National Library of Medicine “The Behavioral	https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4480342/	Government Database	Yes	SubQ 3	Supports importance of interview preparatio	Y	Research shows structured behavioral interviews have	Structured interviews improve fairness and prediction,

Claim	Source	Link	Source type	Is Authoritative Source?	What it supports	Notes	Verified? (Y/N)	Evidence Snipped (1 Line)	Tradeoffs/Conflicts
performance and hiring success than unstructured interviews.	Interview: A Method to Predict Job Success”		(Peer-Reviewed Medical / Research Journal Index)			n methods like STAR.		higher validity in predicting future job success when job-related behaviors are evaluated.	but they require preparation, practice, and interviewer training, which may not always be used in real hiring situations.

Step 4

Title:

Navigating the Job Market as a Young Adult: How resumes, social media, and interview preparation all play a role in determining early job success and hireability

Research Question:

How can college students and young adults improve their chances of getting internships or entry-level jobs without professional experience or paid career services?

Methodology (bullets)

- For this project, we created a research question based on a niche topic and supplemented it with three supporting questions for research and inquiries.
- Using the research question and sub-questions, we utilized AI tools, namely Perplexity, Gemini, and Elicit, to conduct deep research on authoritative sources that support our claims.

- We logged the relevant sources into an evidence table, along with supplemental information such as the claim it supports, links, website, and additional notes.
- Then we decided the sources we would use for our research and verified the source directly from the publishing websites to ensure it supports our claims.
- Finally, we supplemented our evidence table with an evidence snippet quickly summarizing our sources and a tradeoff/conflict section to analyze possible tradeoffs of utilizing that source.

Findings (3 sections based on your 3 sub-questions)

For each sub-question, write 1–2 short paragraphs summarizing what the evidence shows and citing your sources.

SubQ1: What resume and cover letter strategies help entry-level candidates get interviews when they lack formal experience?

SubQ2: How does optimizing LinkedIn profiles and personal branding affect recruiter visibility for students and new grads?

SubQ3: Which interview preparation methods best predict early job success and retention for entry-level employees?

Recommendations (3–5 bullets)

- Add class projects, volunteer work, and campus activities to resumes to show real skills when job experience is limited.
- Complete at least one internship, job shadow, or hands-on project before graduation to improve job chances and salary outcomes.
- Keep LinkedIn updated with skills, projects, and achievements to increase recruiter visibility.
- Practice 5–10 common behavioral interview questions using the STAR method before interviews.

Limitations (2–3 bullets)

- Acknowledge the gaps, constraints, or weaknesses in your evidence or methods.
- Include at least one bullet that explains a clear tradeoff or conflict (e.g., cost vs. quality, convenience vs. accuracy).
- A possible gap in our evidence is that the job market is rapidly changing and developing, especially as AI continues to develop. Many of the sources provided were from prior to 2025, so some of the data may not be as relevant to 2026 graduates and later.

References:

- Include an APA citation of all resources used for the project, including any AI-generated content.

- o See this resource to properly cite AI content:
<https://infoguides.gmu.edu/GenArtificial-Intelligence/citations>

Rivera, Bryan D. "Five Tips to Building a Resume without Work Experience - Career Connections Center." *Career Connections Center*, 18 July 2019, career.ufl.edu/five-tips-to-building-a-resume-without-work-experience/

Gray, Kevin. *NACE DASHBOARD: ACCESS and ANALYZE the NACE 2024 JOB OUTLOOK SURVEY DATA the KEY ATTRIBUTES EMPLOYERS ARE LOOKING for on GRADUATES' RESUMES Average Number of Days between Interview and Job Offer 2023 Recruiting Benchmarks Report*. 2024.

Gorbatov, Sergey, et al. "Get Noticed to Get Ahead: The Impact of Personal Branding on Career Success." *Frontiers in Psychology*, vol. 10, no. 2662, 9 Dec. 2019, www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2019.02662/full.

Cole, M.S., Rubin, R.S., Feild, H.S., & Giles, W.F. (2007). Recruiters' Perceptions and Use of Applicant Résumé Information: Screening the Recent Graduate. *Applied Psychology*, 56, 319-343.

"Internships, Experiential Learning Impact Early Career Success." *Default*, 2025, www.nacweb.org/about-us/press/internships-experiential-learning-impact-early-career-success

Bolli, Thomas, et al. "Valuable Experience: How University Internships Affect Graduates' Income." *Research in Higher Education*, vol. 62, no. 8, 12 May 2021, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11162-021-09637-9>.

Cengagegroup.com, 2025, www.cengagegroup.com/news/press-releases/2025/cengage-group-2025-employability-report/.

"Five Tips to Building a Resume without Work Experience - Career Connections Center." *Career Connections Center*, 18 July 2019, career.ufl.edu/five-tips-to-building-a-resume-without-work-experience/.

“Get Noticed to Get Ahead: The Impact of Personal Branding on Career Success.” *Frontiers in Psychology*, vol. 10, no. 2662, 9 Dec. 2019,

www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fpsyg.2019.02662/full.

“Internships, Experiential Learning Impact Early Career Success.” *Default*, 2025,

naceweb.org/about-us/press/internships-experiential-learning-impact-early-career-success.

L Jane Easdown, et al. “THE BEHAVIORAL INTERVIEW, a METHOD to EVALUATE ACGME COMPETENCIES in RESIDENT SELECTION: A PILOT PROJECT.” *The Journal of Education in Perioperative Medicine : JEPM*, vol. 7, no. 1, 2005, p. E032,

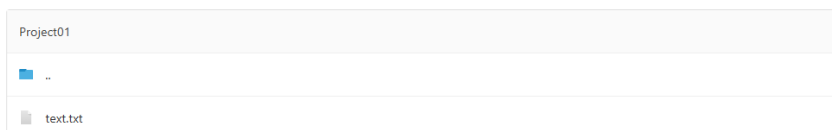
pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4803420/.

OpenAI. “ChatGPT.” *Chatgpt.com*, OpenAI, 12 Sept. 2025, chatgpt.com.

Step 5

- Flo’s Github: <https://gitfront.io/r/flawendy/WYdGvf8haUaj/Spring2026-Group17-AI-Projects/>
- Lily’s Github: <https://gitfront.io/r/ldebell/Mr9Xha7NEzVM/Spring2026-Group17-AI-Projects/>

Spring2026-Group17-AI-Projects / Project01



Powered by [GitFront](https://gitfront.io)

Spring2026-Group17-AI-Projects / Project02

Project02
 ..
 Group6_Pri2.docx
 project2_evidence_log.xlsx - DeepResearch.csv
 test.txt

Powered by [GitFront](#)

Spring2026-Group17-AI-Projects / Project03

Project03
 ..
 test.txt

Powered by [GitFront](#)